

In fact, some practitioners believe that they need to be confident and assertive in order for their patients to trust them, which might harm them in the few instances that they're wrong. And of course doctors get things wrong sometimes, because they're human, and also, their patients are human. In fact, doctors have been known to get things wrong because patients report symptoms that they don't really have. Say you're getting a headache and a runny nose, and look up those symptoms online. One of the diseases mentioned also adds in coughing and itchy throat as a symptom, and you start feeling an itch in your throat. This is kind of like the placebo effect, but in reverse. People have been known to develop or feel like they have symptoms only after reading about them, and this then throws doctors off the trail that leads to the actual disease that you have contracted! In short, leave WebMD and other such sites alone, don't ask family members for advice on what you should or shouldn't do (unless they are doctors themselves), always be honest with your doctor when reporting symptoms, and follow their advice perfectly.

DEBATE

Honestly, is there such a thing anymore? Most of us can remember a time when we could be civilised during disagreements, and learn to respect a difference of opinion. However, because of so many of the points we have mentioned before, it's almost impossible for two people to have a civilised discourse anymore, unless it is on camera, and they happen to be professional scientists taking part in a very structured form of debate.

Those of us interested in politics, especially American politics will have seen how that country is imploding because being childish and calling others names is now considered a virtue, and par for the course! Thankfully we only have a few news anchors here who behave that way, and theft got the idea from American cable news channels anyway... So in essence we can blame this all on the

US, just as we do everything else that is wrong with our lives!

Seriously though, because of the filter bubble we all live in online, the rise of fake news and alternative facts (whatever that means), debate is not just rare anymore, it's downright impossible for us regular folks to indulge in. This is because debate has to have some facts that are unquestionable, and written in stone. For instance, how do you debate a flat earther who believes that the earth is the centre of the universe, is flat, has a dome above it and all the other planets and moons are merely suspended in the sky above? When the two of you cannot agree on basic principles of physics, what really are the ground rules you can set to have such a debate?

The world has moved on to acknowledging feelings and giving them more importance than facts, which is great if you're trying to comfort someone, but it's ridiculous to just treat those feelings as facts. Imagine a court of law where juries would convict or free prisoners based on how they felt about the person? All of our biases about culture and racism would ensure thousands of innocent people would be sent to jail for no fault of their own!

What really would help the matter is to consider speaking (or typing out) in such a manner that mimics how

you would talk to a loved one in front of a crowd of strangers. If everyone did just that much we could all go through life without being called names online for having a difference of opinion.

NEWS / JOURNALISM

Continuing on from the previous point, this one is actually a large cause of all the division that's crept into society. It would be dishonest to think that news or journalism has only now started being dishonest or biased. The fact is that political or religious leanings of a media house puts pressure on their employees to follow the same path, because otherwise they get passed up for raises or bonuses, or even get fired for writing or saying the wrong things.

Unlike most, we cover only science and technology, which means we can ignore sensitive topics such as religion and politics like the plague, and just focus on benchmarking and testing gadgets. Others are not so lucky, we guess, and have to delve into the murky world and get their hands dirty.

The problem is, we'd really like to see news being treated the same way we treat our technology when we're testing it. Establish the facts, take all of the marketing lingo with a huge pinch of salt, and then disregard



An 1802 cartoon of vaccinated men and women growing cow parts on their bodies

Credit: James Gillray/OSU